# From ‘audit society’ to ‘audit planet’

## A systematic review of the non-financial information assurance literature (1990 – 2025)


### Abstract

**Purpose**

Non-financial information assurance (NFIA) has expanded over the past 35 years across public-sector performance audit, sustainability and ESG assurance, and environmental and carbon verification, yet the literature remains fragmented. This review traces the development of empirical NFIA research and assesses how it engages with Michael Power’s later refinements of the audit society.

**Design/methodology/approach**

This study reviews 124 empirical NFIA papers published between 1990 and 2025 in A and A* accounting and auditing journals. It combines bibliometric analysis with inductive coding, interpreted through Power’s audit society refinements, to develop a longitudinal synthesis.

**Findings**

The analysis shows a shift from early public-sector performance auditing towards market-facing sustainability and ESG assurance, alongside emerging carbon and climate practices. Across domains, assurance increasingly prioritises defensible procedures over testing underlying performance, with credibility and risk management often displacing substantive verification. Quantitative studies focus on market effects, while qualitative work highlights negotiated auditability, hybrid expertise and contested professional boundaries as audit becomes an infrastructural feature of governance.

**Research limitations/implications**

By integrating previously siloed assurance domains, the review identifies persistent blind spots, particularly in early-stage auditability construction, political and managerial mediation, and carbon and climate assurance

**Originality/value**

This review offers the first longitudinal, field-level synthesis of empirical NFIA research through Power’s later audit society refinements. It introduces the notion of an ‘audit planet’ to capture how verification increasingly operates as background infrastructure rather than as a discrete checking activity.

**Keywords**

Non-financial information assurance; systematic literature review; audit society; sustainability assurance; performance audit; carbon assurance

**Paper type**

Literature Review

## Introduction

Over the past three decades, auditing has moved well beyond financial statements and become a pervasive mode of verification shaping how organisations, markets and governments are governed (Dalla Via & Perego, 2020; Power, 1996; Power, 2003a). Across public-sector performance, corporate sustainability, climate risk and ESG reporting, verification is viewed as infrastructure (Aquino, Lino, Azevedo and Silva, 2022; Power, 1996); in practice, however, its reach is uneven and constrained by mandate, scope and access to evidence (Ackers & Eccles, 2015; Bouten & Hoozée, 2025; English, 2007; Funnell & Wade, 2012). Independent non-financial information assurance (NFIA) increasingly underpins how social, environmental and organisational processes are made visible and comparable across jurisdictions. (Perego & Kolk, 2012; Simnett, Vanstraelen and Chua, 2009). Taken together, these developments point to a significant shift in the nature of audit itself: from a bounded professional practice into a globally dispersed system of verification operating across public and private domains, increasingly embedded within data architectures (Gu, Dai and Vasarhelyi, 2023; Vasarhelyi, Alles and Williams, 2015), management systems (Dogui, Boiral and Gendron, 2013; Morimoto, Ash and Hope, 2005), and regulatory routines (Aquino *et al*., 2022; Kastberg & Ek Österberg, 2017).

A substantial empirical literature has documented this expansion of non-financial assurance (Ackers, 2009; Ackers & Eccles, 2015; Dalla Via & Perego, 2020; Gipper, Ross and Shi, 2025; Simnett *et al*., 2009). Prior studies consistently show that

NFIA is characterised by the dominance of large accounting firms, the use of standardised assurance frameworks, and its growing relevance for credibility, legitimacy, and capital-market outcomes (Guthrie & Parker, 1999; Perego & Kolk, 2012; Ackers, 2015; Casey & Grenier, 2015). More recent work highlights the acceleration of NFIA into ESG, carbon accounting, and digitally mediated assurance environments, extending verification practices into technically complex and future-oriented domains (Green, Taylor and Wu, 2017; Xing, Shan, Yang and Zhang, 2025). Overall, the literature indicates that NFIA has moved closer to the centre of accountability practice, while the substance of what is verified remains selectively delimited (Boiral, Heras-Saizarbitoria, Brotherton and Bernard, 2019; Bouten & Hoozée, 2025; Hummel, Schlick and Fifka, 2019; Morin, 2011; O'Dwyer, Owen and Unerman, 2011).

At the same time, existing reviews and empirical syntheses tend to examine NFIA through narrowly defined subdomains—such as sustainability and integrated reporting assurance or greenwashing-related assurance—rather than synthesising the longitudinal development of NFIA as a field (Farooq, Azantouti and Zaman, 2023; Free, Jones & Tremblay, 2024; Massaro, Dumay and Guthrie, 2016; Linnenluecke, Marrone and Singh, 2020; Fan, Breslin, Callahan and Iszatt-White, 2022). While these studies provide valuable domain-specific insights, they remain conceptually siloed, offering limited engagement with the shared institutional logics that connect public-sector performance auditing, CSR assurance, ESG verification, and emerging carbon

assurance practices (Boiral *et al*., 2019; Bouten & Hoozée, 2025; Parker, Schmitz and Jacobs, 2021; Silvola & Vinnari, 2021).

This fragmentation matters because it hides the extent to which similar assurance logics are being reproduced across otherwise disconnected domains. Analysing NFIA subdomains in isolation obscures the systemic transformation of verification practices across governance domains (Humphrey & Miller, 2012; Power, 1996; Power, 2003b). The expansion of assurance into social and atmospheric domains is not merely a technical extension of audit, but a fundamental reconfiguration of how legitimacy and professional authority are produced (Power, 2003a). Without an integrated analytical lens, much of the empirical NFIA literature documents proliferation without diagnosis—capturing the spread of assurance practices while leaving their broader governance implications under-theorised (Boiral *et al*., 2019; Humphrey, 2008; O'Dwyer *et al*., 2011; Radcliffe, 2008). As a result, the literature struggles to explain how diverse assurance practices collectively contribute to new forms of regulation, responsibility, and accountability (Ackers & Eccles, 2015; Farooq & de Villiers, 2020; Humphrey & Miller, 2012; Morin, 2011), or how they reshape professional identities and organisational behaviour across sectors (Channuntapipat, Samsonova-Taddei and Turley, 2019; Gaudy & Malsch, 2023; Justesen & Skærbæk, 2010; Skærbæk, 2009).

This study draws on Michael Power's later refinements of the audit society to address this gap. While Power's original diagnosis of an expanding "audit society"

highlighted the proliferation of verification practices (Power, 1997a), his subsequent work shifted attention towards the mechanisms through which audit produces legitimacy, governs at a distance, and increasingly focuses on the "control of control" rather than first-order activities (Power, 2003a; Power, 2003b). These refinements place emphasis on procedural legitimacy, symbolic verification, system-based governance and the construction of audit subjectivities—concerns that resonate strongly with contemporary NFIA practices (Boiral *et al.*, 2019; Kastberg & Ek Österberg, 2017; O'Dwyer *et al.*, 2011)

Yet, despite their relevance, Power's later refinements remain only unevenly engaged in review-based syntheses of NFIA. Recent reviews typically concentrate on particular assurance domains—such as sustainability and integrated reporting assurance or greenwashing-related assurance—rather than systematically examining the longitudinal development of NFIA as a field through Power's audit society refinements (Farooq *et al.*, 2023; Free, Jones & Tremblay, 2024). As a result**,** NFIA represents a privileged site for revisiting and empirically evaluating these theoretical claims. Unlike financial auditing, which has become stabilised and largely blackboxed (Humphrey, 2008; Power, 1996), NFIA remains visibly "in the making" (Boiral, Heras-Saizarbitoria and Brotherton, 2020; Power, 1996; Xu & Andrew, 2021), marked by contested standards, hybrid expertise, and uneven institutionalisation (Boiral *et al.*, 2020; Bouten & Hoozée, 2025; Channuntapipat, Samsonova-Taddei and Turley, 2020; Xu & Andrew, 2021). Examining NFIA through this lens enables a field-

level assessment of how contemporary verification practices contribute to legitimacy production, symbolic reassurance, governance and control, and the reshaping of professional identities in an increasingly audit-saturated world (Boiral *et al*., 2019; Justesen & Skærbæk, 2010; Power, 2003a; Skærbæk, 2009).

In light of these developments, a systematic re-examination of the empirical NFIA literature is warranted to assess both how the field has evolved and how it engages with the later theoretical refinements of the audit society (Power, 2003a, 2003b). Against this background, the review asks two practical questions about how NFIA research has evolved and what it actually explains:

**RQ1.** How has the empirical literature on NFIA developed over the past 35 years?

**RQ2.** To what extent does the empirical NFIA literature engage with the later theoretical refinements of the audit society advanced by Power (2003a, 2003b), and what does this reveal about how legitimacy production, symbolic verification practices, governance and control, and professional identities are empirically conceptualised and examined in non-financial assurance research?

To address these questions, this review adopts a broad conception of non-financial information assurance. NFIA is defined as independent assurance engagements over non-financial subject matter, spanning both public and private sector contexts, and encompassing practices such as performance audit, sustainability and ESG assurance, carbon and greenhouse gas verification, environmental audit, and compliance-oriented non-financial audits (Hasan, Maijoor,

Mock, Roebuck, Simnett and Vanstraelen, 2005; Moroney, Campbell, Hamilton and Warren, 2020). This definition reflects how assurance is enacted in practice rather than how it is segmented within academic silos. It includes both accounting-led and multidisciplinary assurance arrangements, while excluding internal audits and specialist inspections lacking independence. By treating audit and assurance as analytically connected practices within a shared verification regime, the review situates NFIA within a continuous tradition of non-financial verification rather than as a collection of discrete service types (O'Dwyer, 2011; Power, 1996).

This review makes three contributions aimed at clarifying how NFIA operates in practice rather than how it is typically described. First, it offers the first longitudinal, field-level synthesis of 35 years of empirical research on non-financial assurance, integrating evidence across public-sector performance audit, CSR and ESG assurance, environmental and carbon verification, and related domains. By consolidating previously fragmented findings, the review shows how NFIA has evolved from marginal accountability experiments into a central infrastructure of contemporary governance. Second, the review provides a theoretically informed evaluation of NFIA by systematically interpreting the empirical literature through Power's later refinements of the audit society. In doing so, it moves beyond treating Power's work as a background metaphor and instead assesses how procedural legitimacy, symbolic verification, system-based control, and audit subjectivities are empirically enacted across non-financial assurance practices (Power, 2003a; Power,

2003b). This bridges a longstanding gap between theory and evidence in audit society research. Third, the review advances the conceptual proposition of an audit planet to capture the infrastructural, generative, and world-making role of contemporary verification. By identifying persistent tensions, blind spots and under-explored domains—particularly in emerging areas such as carbon and climate assurance—the review develops a future research agenda that shifts attention from documenting audit expansion to critically analysing how audit reshapes governance, responsibility, and professional authority at scale.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. Section 2 outlines the theoretical foundations of the audit society perspective, with particular emphasis on Power's later refinements concerning legitimacy production, symbolic verification, governance and control, and professional identities. Section 3 describes the systematic review methodology, including data collection, bibliometric analysis, and thematic coding procedures. Section 4 presents the empirical synthesis of the NFIA literature, organised around key themes and sub-themes. Section 5 discusses the findings in relation to Power's theoretical framework, develops the audit planet proposition, and concludes with implications, limitations, and directions for future research.

## Conceptual Foundations: The Evolution of the Audit Society

The conceptualisation of auditing as a pervasive social and organisational phenomenon is most commonly traced to Michael Power (1997a)'s concept of *Audit Society* (Funnell & Wade, 2012; Humphrey & Miller, 2012; Morin, 2011). In this seminal work, Power challenged conventional understandings of audit as a neutral, technical practice by situating it within a broader regulatory and cultural context characterised by heightened demands for verification, transparency and control. However, while the book established the now-canonical diagnosis of an expanding "audit society" (Power, 1997a), a fuller understanding of this theoretical trajectory requires deeper engagement with Power's earlier constructivist intervention (Power, 1996) and his subsequent analytical refinements in the early twenty-first century (Power, 2003a, 2003b). Together, these works provide the analytical resources necessary to move beyond the macro-metaphor of the audit society and towards a more detailed understanding of the backstage mechanics through which verification is practically accomplished.

The theoretical foundations of this programme were laid in *Making Things Auditable* (Power, 1996), where auditability was explicitly theorised as an accomplished rather than an inherent property of organisational activities. Power rejected the "official image" of audit as a derived activity that merely adds credibility to pre-existing facts, arguing instead that auditing actively constructs the legitimacy of its own knowledge base while simultaneously shaping the organisational environments in which that knowledge can operate successfully. This process of

“making things auditable” was illustrated through three distinct strategies of fact construction. These ideas were subsequently elaborated and given institutional specificity in Power’s analysis of environmental auditing (Power, 1997b), which showed how auditability is extended to new domains through the re-framing of substantive phenomena as systems of control, verification, and management. In that context, auditability emerged not as a response to pre-given environmental facts, but as the outcome of professional and regulatory strategies that repositioned verification around organisational systems, enabling auditors to claim authority while subordinating alternative forms of expertise.

In the context of public sector research, auditability is achieved through the development of detailed measurement technologies—such as time-recording systems—that translate academic labour into a surface of auditable facts. In the domain of quality management, auditability is accomplished through abstract management systems (for example, ISO 9000), which provide a bureaucratic infrastructure upon which audit processes can operate independently of substantive performance outcomes. In the case of brand valuation, auditability is negotiated through reliance on the institutional credibility of other experts, such that verification becomes a function of distributed trust rather than direct inspection. Across these cases, auditing does not simply verify an existing organisational order; it reshapes organisational practices and representations in ways that make audit itself possible (Power, 1996).

This constructivist insight was subsequently generalised in *The Audit Society* (Power, 1997a), where the diffusion of financial audit logics into non-financial domains was characterised as an "audit explosion". Power (1997a) argued that these expanding rituals of verification underpin a broader administrative style of "governing at a distance", enabling central authorities to maintain an image of control within increasingly decentralised and fragmented organisational settings. Crucially, Power emphasised that such verification practices do not necessarily enhance substantive accountability. Rather, they often function to generate reassurance—or "comfort"—for external audiences, producing displacement effects whereby compliance artefacts, documentation and working papers become ends in themselves. In this logic of auditability, the requirement for activities to be auditable increasingly converges with the requirement for them to be *seen* to be auditable, loosening the connection between verification practices and underlying organisational performance.

While the 1997 book provided a powerful diagnosis, Power's subsequent work offered the analytical refinement required for closer empirical engagement. In "Auditing and the Production of Legitimacy", Power (2003a) redirected attention from macro-level expansion to the internal social organisation of audit practice. He argued that because audit quality is inherently difficult to observe and evaluate, it must be defined procedurally within the profession itself. Legitimacy is therefore produced through collective interaction, routinised judgement and the progressive purification

of organisational uncertainty. In this account, working papers function as a distinctive genre of organisational text, designed to present a rational and defensible representation of practice for anticipated external audiences, particularly regulators and courts. The writing of auditing thus becomes a central mechanism through which administrative objectivity is stabilised, while the contingent and negotiated character of audit work is largely rendered invisible.

A complementary perspective is provided in *Evaluating the Audit Explosion* (Power, 2003b), which offered a more differentiated and comparative account of audit expansion. Here, Power reconceptualised the audit explosion not simply as growth in audit activity, but as a qualitative shift towards the "control of control". In this mode, auditing increasingly focuses on management systems, self-monitoring processes and internal controls rather than on first-order operational activities. Power (2003b) introduced a comparative framework for analysing this variation, structured around differences in knowledge bases, formal organisational arrangements and operational processes. This analysis also foregrounded the emergence of the auditee as a distinctive administrative subject: a professionalised actor skilled in managing inspection regimes, engaging in defensive documentation practices and navigating what Power described as games of compliance. Within this configuration, auditing becomes closely aligned with blame avoidance and risk management, reinforcing procedural compliance over substantive critique.

A recurring theme across this evolutionary trajectory concerns the relationship between audit and assurance. Power's work suggests that the rise of assurance services should be understood less as a conceptual rupture than as a process of professional reinvention, in which established audit techniques are reassembled and extended into new domains under alternative vocabularies (Power, 2003a). Subsequent research supports this interpretation, demonstrating that the language of assurance was strategically introduced during the mid-1990s by professional standard-setters to facilitate market expansion into areas such as sustainability reporting and internal controls (Sonnerfeldt & Pontoppidan, 2020). While technical distinctions are sometimes articulated—most commonly between verification as completeness checking and assurance as confirmation of truthfulness—these distinctions appear to be driven more by market differentiation and regulatory framing than by substantive conceptual divergence (Sonnerfeldt & Pontoppidan, 2020).

Empirical studies further underscore this convergence in practice. In the context of non-financial reporting, terms such as "external assurance", "verification" and "sustainability audit" are frequently used interchangeably to describe substantively similar validation processes (Bartoszewicz & Rutkowska-Ziarko, 2021). Moreover, these practices are functionally inseparable: assurance engagements rely upon prior processes of verification to construct the auditable facts on which opinions are based (Bartoszewicz & Rutkowska-Ziarko, 2021). For the purposes of this systematic literature review, audit and assurance are therefore treated as analytically connected

practices within a shared verification regime. This position is consistent with Power's constructivist insight that what ultimately matters is not terminological distinction, but the underlying processes through which auditability is constructed, legitimacy is produced and institutional comfort is maintained. Viewed in this way, contemporary audit and assurance practices can be understood as manifestations of the same administrative style that continues to define the modern audit society.

## Review Design and Methodology

To address the NFIA literature's breadth and theoretical density, the review proceeds in stages, combining systematic searching with bibliometric mapping and close reading of full texts. First, a systematic literature review (SLR) ensures transparent identification of the field's boundaries. Subsequent descriptive and narrative abstract analyses map 35 years of research, identifying longitudinal patterns in journals, topics, and jurisdictions to address RQ1. Bibliometric keyword co-occurrence and intellectual clustering complement this mapping. These patterns identify thematic clusters informed by the "accounting complex" (Miller & Power, 2013), which are refined through inductive full-text coding and temporal analyses to trace thematic maturation. Finally, the thematic structure is analyzed using Power's later audit society refinements (Power, 2003a, 2003b). Power's conceptual concerns—legitimacy production, symbolic verification, governance,

and professional identities—serve as sensitizing devices rather than a priori categories, allowing for an interpretive evaluation of contemporary research (RQ2).

*Systematic Literature Review*

Standalone literature reviews are increasingly recognised as rigorous research methods capable of generating novel insights through systematic synthesis (Tranfield, Denyer and Smart, 2003; Okoli, 2015). Drawing on the miner–prospector continuum (Breslin & Gatrell, 2023), this review adopts a "prospector" approach, seeking to consolidate and problematize fragmented empirical findings while preparing the ground for theoretically informed analysis.

The SLR aligns with established benchmarks for impact: rigor, generativity, scope, and transparency (Fan *et al*., 2022). By following best-practice protocols to minimize bias and subjectivity (Snyder, 2019; Linnenluecke *et al*., 2020), this approach reflects how SLRs are now used in accounting research to consolidate dispersed empirical findings rather than to test hypotheses (Massaro *et al*., 2016). Adhering to the core attributes of reproducibility and comprehensive scope (Okoli, 2015), this design is particularly effective given the study's well-defined parameters and manageable dataset (Donthu, Kumar, Mukherjee, Pandey and Lim, 2021). To identify NFIA literature from 1990 to 2025, we applied a systematic keyword strategy across major databases. Search terms were developed using Boolean operators (Wang, Scells, Koopman and Zuccon, 2023) and

informed by professional auditing frameworks and literature (Hasan *et al*., 2005; Moroney *et al*., 2020). This inclusive set of keywords, summarized in Table 1, ensures coverage across all primary NFIA domains.

| **NFIA subject domains** | **Keywords** |
|---|---|
| Environment(al) | environmental audit, environmental assurance, externality audit, pollution audit |
| Compliance | compliance audit, compliance assurance |
| Performance | performance audit, efficiency audit, effectiveness audit, government program audit |
| ISO | ISO audit, ISO assurance |
| Webtrust | WebTrust assurance, WebTrust audit, e-commerce assurance |
| Sustainability | sustainability audit, sustainability assurance |
| CSR | corporate social responsibility audit, CSR assurance, CSR audit, social responsibility assurance, corporate citizenship audit |
| ESG | environmental, social, and governance audit, ESG assurance, ESG performance audit, ESG performance assurance |
| Carbon (GHG) | greenhouse gas emission audit, carbon audit, emissions assurance, GHG audit, GHG assurance, carbon verification |

**Table 1. NFIA subject domains and associated search keywords**

*Source: Developed by the author using Boolean search strategies informed by Wang et al. (2023), Hasan et al. (2005), and Moroney et al. (2020)*

To ensure a comprehensive, high-quality corpus covering 1990–2025, we searched Scopus, EBSCO, Web of Science, and ProQuest. Study selection followed a transparent protocol based on four predefined criteria:

1. Quality: Peer-reviewed articles from "A" or "A*" accounting/auditing journals (2022 ABDC list).
2. Language: English-only publications.

3. Nature: Empirical studies (conceptual papers and policy commentaries excluded).
4. Relevance: Substantive engagement with auditing or assurance.

We identified 41 target journals from the ABDC list by screening for titles containing "accounting" or "audit," while including relevant exceptions such as *Abacus* and *Journal of Business Ethics* due to their significant NFIA contributions. This final journal list is detailed in Table 2.

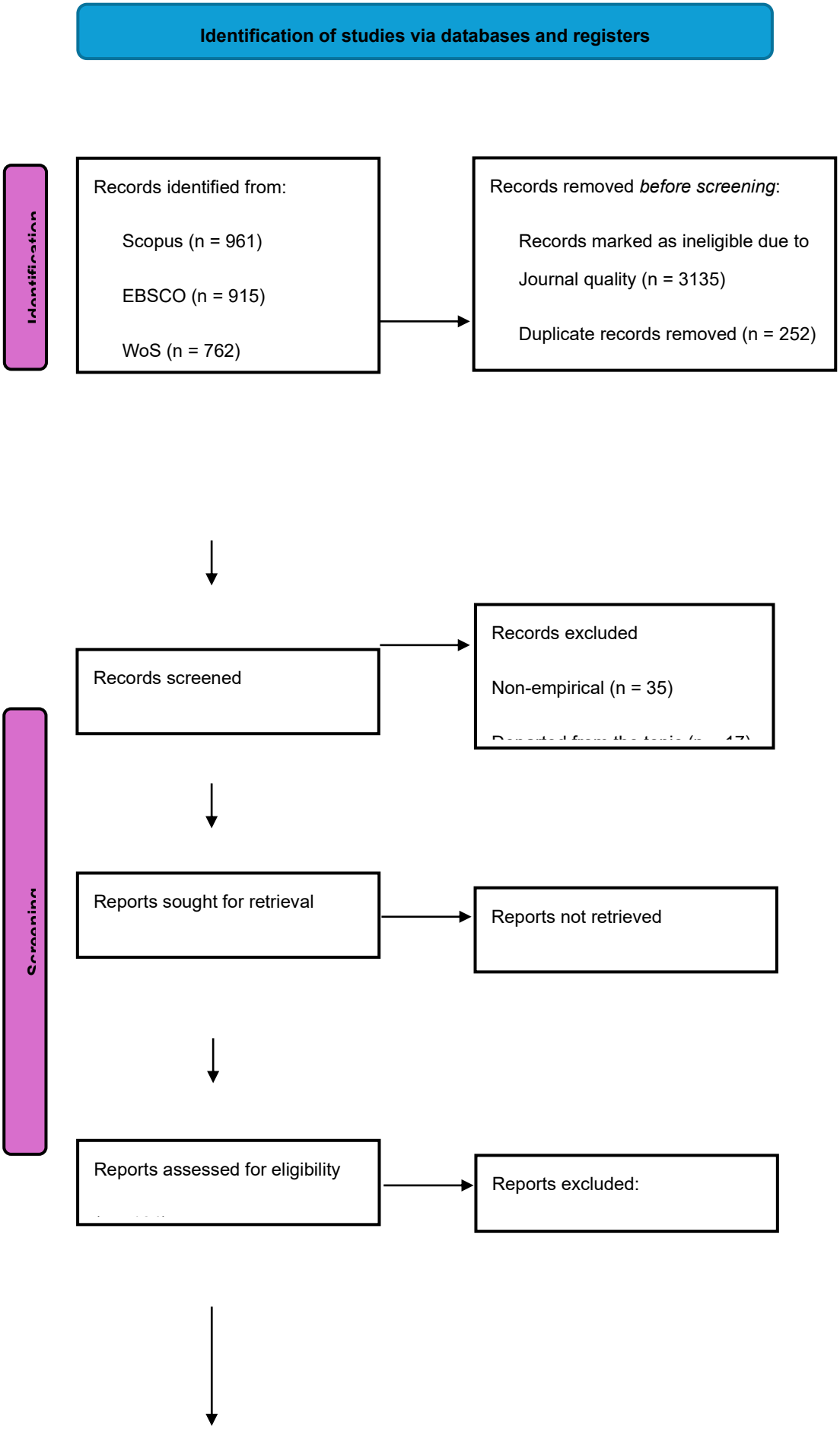
| | **Journal Title** | **Year Inception** | **2022 rating** |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Accounting Auditing and Accountability Journal | 1988 | A* |
| 2 | Accounting, Organizations and Society | 1976 | A* |
| 3 | Auditing: A Journal of Practice and Theory | 1981 | A* |
| 4 | British Accounting Review | 1968 | A* |
| 5 | Contemporary Accounting Research | 1984 | A* |
| 6 | Journal of Accounting and Economics | 1979 | A* |
| 7 | Journal of Accounting Research | 1963 | A* |
| 8 | Journal of Business Finance & Accounting | 1974 | A* |
| 9 | Journal of Management Accounting Research | 1989 | A* |
| 10 | Management Accounting Research | 1990 | A* |
| 11 | Review of Accounting Studies | 1996 | A* |
| 12 | The Accounting Review | 1926 | A* |
| 13 | The European Accounting Review | 1992 | A* |
| 14 | Abacus | 1965 | A |
| 15 | Accounting and Business Research | 1970 | A |
| 16 | Accounting and Finance | 1961 | A |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 17 | Accounting Education | 1992 | A |
| 18 | Accounting History | 1989 | A |
| 19 | Accounting Horizons | 1987 | A |
| 20 | Accounting in Europe | 2004 | A |
| 21 | Advances in Accounting | 1984 | A |
| 22 | Advances in Accounting Behavioral Research | 1998 | A |
| 23 | Advances in Management Accounting | 1990 | A |
| 24 | Behavioral Research in Accounting | 1989 | A |
| 25 | China Accounting and Finance Review | 1999 | A |
| 26 | Critical Perspectives on Accounting | 1990 | A |
| 27 | Financial Accountability and Management | 1985 | A |
| 28 | Foundations and Trends in Accounting | 2006 | A |
| 29 | International Journal of Accounting Information Systems | 2000 | A |
| 30 | International Journal of Auditing | 1997 | A |
| 31 | Issues in Accounting Education | 1983 | A |
| 32 | Journal of Accounting and Public Policy | 1982 | A |
| 33 | Journal of Accounting Auditing and Finance | 1986 | A |
| 34 | Journal of Accounting Literature | 1981 | A |
| 35 | Journal of Business Ethics | 1982 | A |
| 36 | Journal of Contemporary Accounting and Economics | 2005 | A |
| 37 | Journal of International Accounting Research | 2002 | A |
| 38 | Managerial Auditing Journal | 1986 | A |
| 39 | Meditari Accountancy Research | 1993 | A |
| 40 | Qualitative Research in Accounting and Management | 2004 | A |
| 41 | The International Journal of Accounting | 1965 | A |

**Table 2. Top accounting journals (based on ABDC lists)**

*Source: ABDC (2022)*

The article selection protocol was pilot-tested in early 2025 to refine keyword combinations and inclusion criteria. Final database searches in November 2025 yielded 3,551 records (Scopus: 961; EBSCO: 915; ProQuest: 913; Web of Science: 762). Following PRISMA guidance (Page *et al.*, 2021), as illustrated in Figure 1, we applied ABDC quality filters and performed manual, line-by-line deduplication via EndNote. This initial screening reduced the corpus to 176 unique records. During abstract review, an additional 52 studies were excluded (35 non-empirical; 17 marginally relevant), resulting in a final dataset of 124 empirical studies for full-text analysis.


Identification of studies via databases and registers
Identification
Records identified from:
Scopus (n = 961)
EBSCO (n = 915)
WoS (n = 762)
Records removed *before screening*:
Records marked as ineligible due to
Journal quality (n = 3135)
Duplicate records removed (n = 252)
Screening
Records screened
Records excluded
Non-empirical (n = 35)
Reports sought for retrieval
Reports not retrieved
Reports assessed for eligibility
Reports excluded:

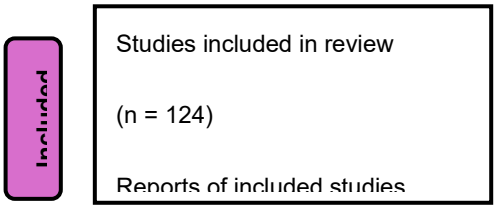



**Figure 1: Prisma flowchart of the article search and selection process for systematic review**
*Source: Figure by author, adapted from Page et al. (2021). Licensed under CC BY 4.0*

The following section presents the descriptive results of the systematic literature review, providing an overview of the temporal distribution, publication outlets, methodological approaches and topical focus of empirical NFIA research (RQ1).

*Descriptive Results*

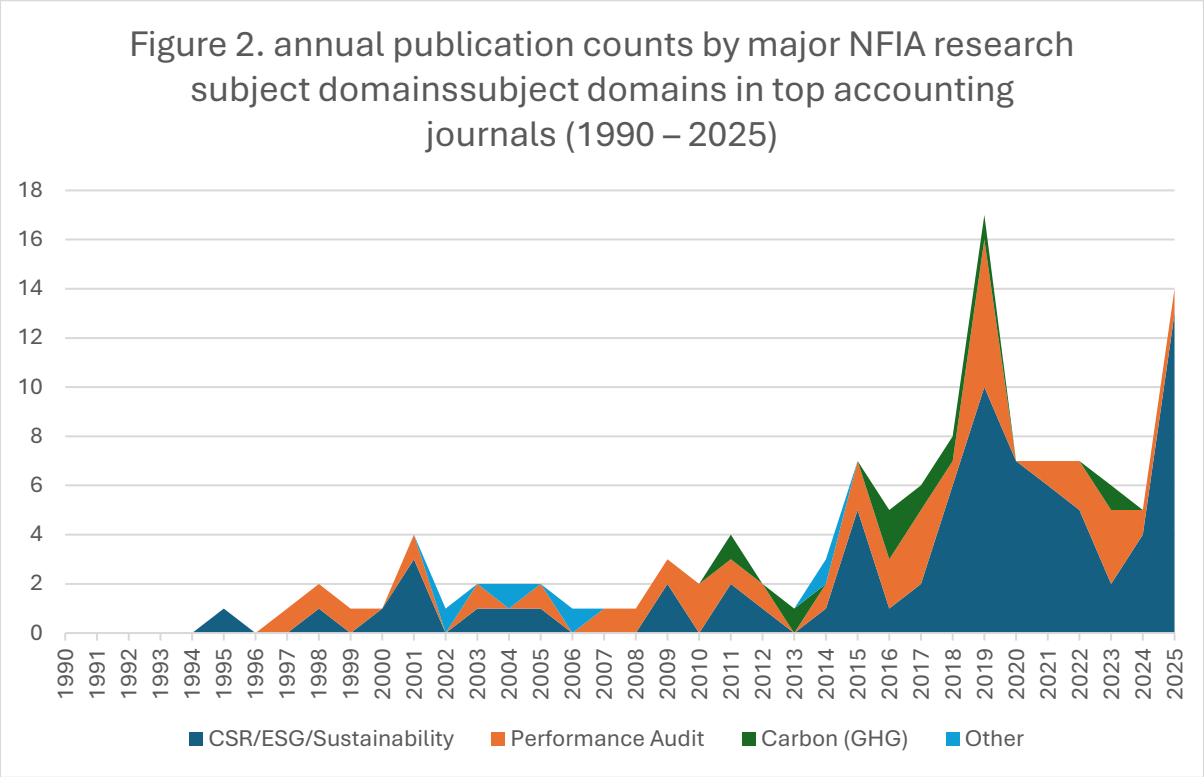



**Figure 2: annual publication counts by major NFIA research subject domains in top accounting journals (1990 – 2025)**
*Source: Author's analysis*

The annual distribution of NFIA publications (1990–2025) reveals two dominant trajectories (see Figure 2). First, performance auditing represents the field's most persistent strand, appearing consistently since the late 1990s. This stability underscores its foundational role in the expansion of audit beyond financial reporting, particularly within public-sector accountability research. Second, CSR, ESG, and sustainability assurance research experienced exponential growth starting in 2011, becoming the literature's dominant stream. This expansion accelerated post-2015 and peaked in the late 2010s, a pattern consistent with intensified global climate-policy attention and corporate responsibility agendas (Perego & Kolk, 2012). Publication volumes dipped

during 2022–2023, which may reflect COVID-19–related disruptions to research production and publication processes. Notably, sustainability-related assurance remains at historically high levels, while emerging domains like carbon and GHG auditing persist as significant but smaller niche streams.

| Journal / Jurisdiction of Study | Global | Australia | China | UK | US | Other Developed Countries | Other Developing Countries | Total |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Abacus | | 1 | | | | | | **1** |
| Accounting & Finance | 2 | | | | | 1 | | **3** |
| Accounting & Business Research | | 1 | | | | 2 | 1 | **4** |
| Accounting Horizons | | | 1 | | | | | **1** |
| Accounting in Europe | | | | | | 1 | | **1** |
| Accounting, Auditing & Accountability Journal | 3 | 4 | | 1 | | 4 | 1 | **13** |
| Accounting, Organizations and Society | 1 | | | | 2 | 2 | | **5** |
| Auditing: A Journal of Practice & Theory | 4 | 1 | 1 | | 3 | | | **9** |
| Behavioral Research in Accounting | | 1 | | | | | | **1** |

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Contemporary Accounting Research | 4 | | | | | 1 | | **5** |
| Critical Perspectives on Accounting | | 1 | | | 1 | 2 | 1 | **5** |
| European Accounting Review | 1 | | | 1 | | 1 | | **3** |
| Financial Accountability & Management | 1 | 5 | | 1 | | 6 | 2 | **15** |
| Financial Accountability and Management | | | | 1 | | | | **1** |
| International Journal of Accounting Information Systems | 2 | | | | | | | **2** |
| International Journal of Auditing | 2 | 1 | 3 | | | 3 | 2 | **11** |
| Journal of Accounting and Public Policy | 1 | | 1 | | | | | **2** |
| Journal of Applied Accounting Research | 1 | | | | 1 | 1 | 1 | **4** |
| Journal of Business Ethics | 7 | | 1 | | 2 | 2 | | **12** |
| Journal of Contemporary Accounting & Economics | | 1 | | | | | | **1** |

| | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Journal of International Accounting Research | 1 | | | | | | | **1** |
| Managerial Auditing Journal | | 3 | 1 | 1 | | 3 | 1 | **9** |
| Meditari Accountancy Research | | 1 | | | | 3 | 2 | **6** |
| Qualitative Research in Accounting & Management | | | | | | 2 | | **2** |
| Review of Accounting Studies | | | | | 1 | | | **1** |
| The Accounting Review | | | | | 1 | | | **1** |
| The British Accounting Review | | 1 | 2 | 1 | | 1 | | **5** |
| **Grand Total** | **30** | **21** | **10** | **6** | **11** | **35** | **11** | **124** |

**Table 3. Distribution of empirical NFIA studies by journal outlet and jurisdiction of study**

*Source: Author's analysis*

Table 3 summarises the journal and jurisdictional distribution of NFIA studies, revealing high concentration among a few key outlets. *Financial Accountability & Management*, *AAAJ*, *Journal of Business Ethics*, and *International Journal of Auditing* dominate the corpus. This concentration underscores these journals' established leadership in public-sector accountability and sustainability governance.

Geographically, Australia is a dominant empirical setting in this corpus, surpassing the UK; this concentration is consistent with the prominence of performance audit within Australian public-sector accountability research (Guthrie & Parker, 1999; Parker, Jacobs and Schmitz, 2019) Developed European contexts (e.g., France and Germany) drive a large share of research centered on carbon and public-sector audits. Notably, China has emerged as a distinct cluster, with ten studies focused exclusively on CSR and sustainability assurance.

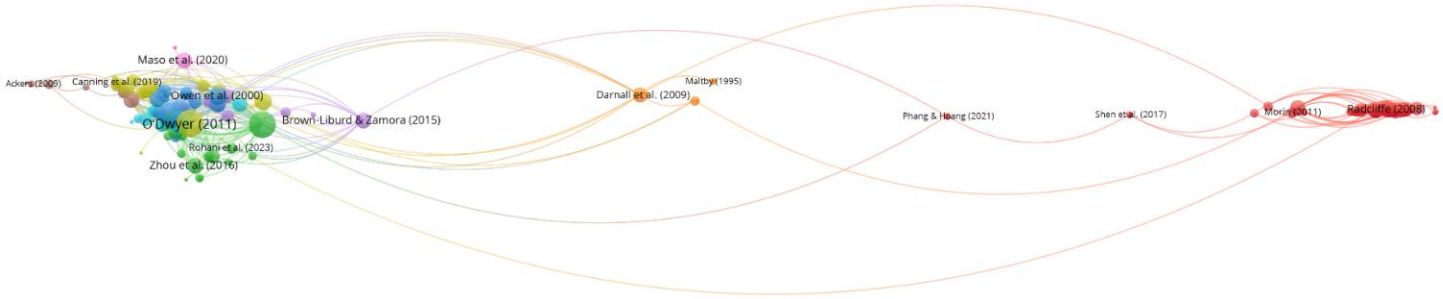
| Main Research Method / Subject Domains | CSR/ESG/ Sustainability | Performance Audit | Carbon (GHG) | Other | Total |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Archival / statistical analysis | 33 | 3 | 3 | | **39** |
| Case study | 7 | 11 | | 2 | **20** |
| Discourse / content analysis | 5 | 1 | | | **6** |
| Document / textual analysis | 5 | 6 | | | **11** |
| Experimental / quasi-experimental | 9 | | 2 | 1 | **12** |
| Interview study | 9 | 9 | | 1 | **19** |
| Participant observation | 1 | | | | **1** |
| Survey | 7 | 6 | 3 | | **16** |
| **Grand Total** | **76** | **36** | **8** | **4** | **124** |

**Table 4. Distribution of research methods across NFIA subject domains**
*Source: Author's analysis*

Table 4 reveals distinct methodological preferences across NFIA domains. Archival and statistical analyses dominate CSR, ESG, and sustainability assurance research, leveraging the increasing availability of large-sample non-financial datasets. Conversely, performance audit research relies predominantly on qualitative approaches—case studies, interviews, and document analysis—to examine the institutional processes and organizational practices unique to public-sector settings. While CSR and sustainability studies maintain a balance between quantitative and qualitative designs, experimental and quasi-experimental methods are almost exclusively confined to this domain. Survey-based research remains distributed across both sustainability and performance audit contexts.

Collectively, these results document a transition in NFIA research: from early public-sector performance auditing toward a methodologically plural field currently dominated by sustainability-focused studies across diverse institutional settings.

*Bibliometric Results*



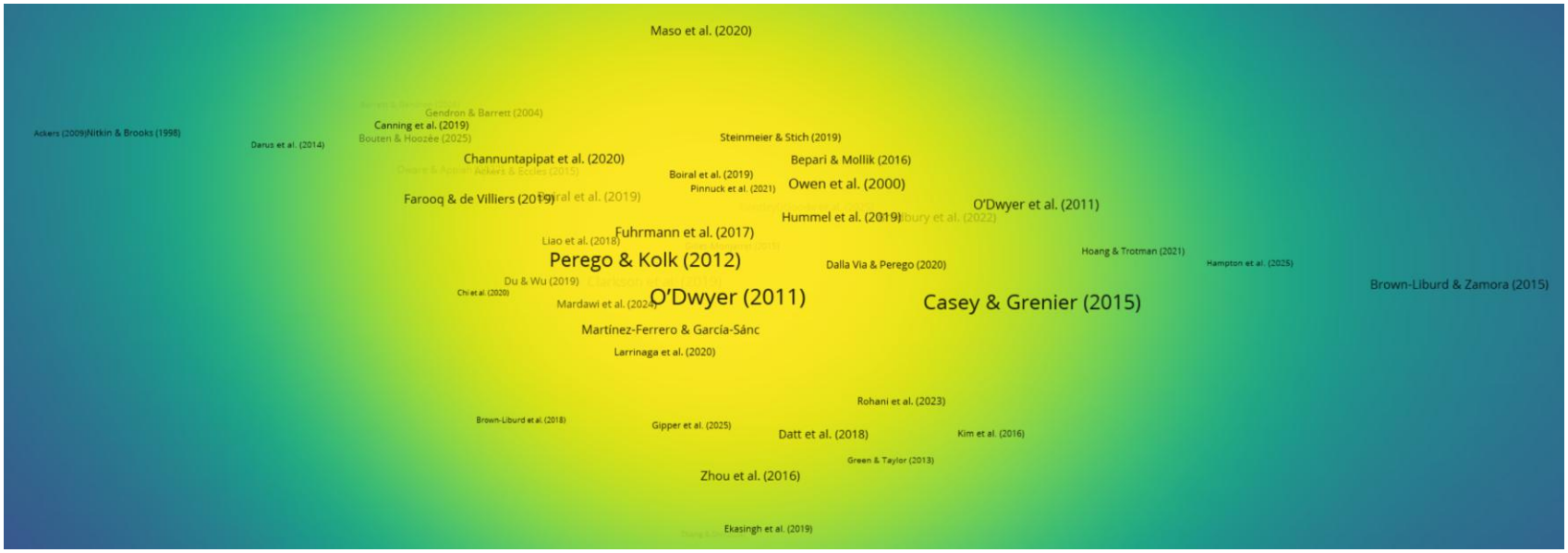



**Figure 3.** Internal citation network and density visualisation of influential NFIA studies based on within-corpus citations
*Source: Author's analysis*

The internal citation structure (Figure 3) reveals a dense, coherent research field. With 114 of the 124 studies linked through within-corpus references, the literature is characterised by shared intellectual foundations rather than isolated inquiries. Density mapping identifies O'Dwyer (2011), Perego and Kolk (2012), and Casey and Grenier (2015) as the corpus's primary intellectual anchors. Collectively, these foundational works establish the core empirical themes of the field: O'Dwyer (2011) examines the construction of auditability in the absence of standards; Perego and Kolk (2012) document the global diffusion and symbolic decoupling of sustainability assurance; and Casey and Grenier (2015) demonstrate the capital market benefits of accounting-led CSR assurance. These studies provide the empirical basis for the thematic synthesis that follows. Beyond internal links, the corpus remains anchored by foundational external theory and practitioner developments. Power (1997a) is cited by nearly half of the reviewed studies, confirming the enduring influence of the original "audit society" thesis. Furthermore, the extensive citation of practitioner reports—particularly from KPMG—may indicate that academic research in NFIA has often developed in close dialogue with professional innovations, rather than setting the pace of assurance-framework development (Perego & Kolk, 2012; Casey & Grenier, 2015). This practitioner-led trajectory underscores the field's pragmatic origins and its ongoing struggle to stabilize theoretical boundaries.

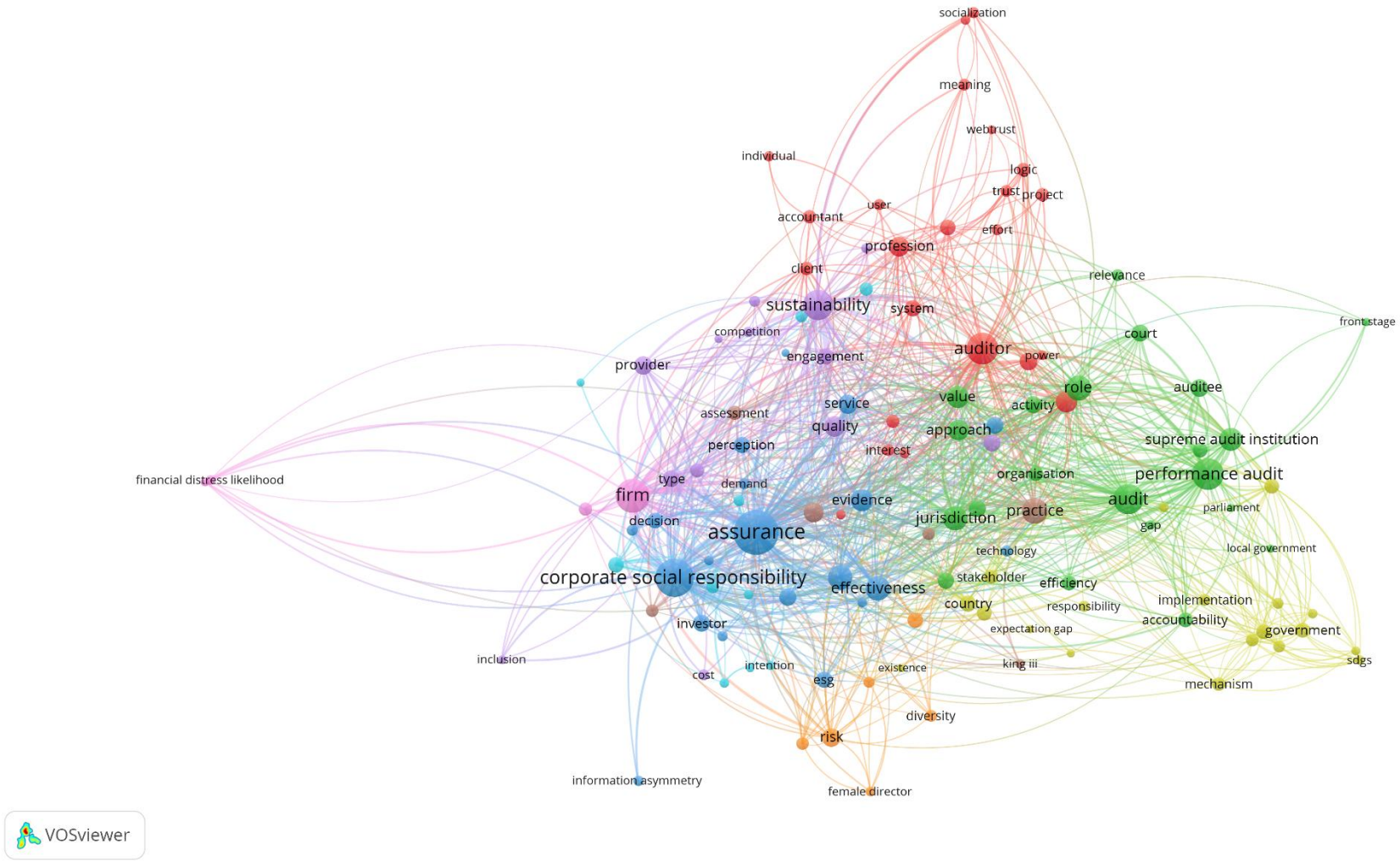



**Figure 4.** Network visualisation of keyword co-occurrence in the NFIA literature

*Source: Author's analysis*

Figure 4 visualises the keyword co-occurrence network, constructed using a refined thesaurus to reduce lexical fragmentation. We employed a full-count matrix to consolidate synonyms into high-order conceptual categories—for instance, normalizing organizational forms to “firm” and disparate assurance terms to “assurance.” Noise reduction was achieved by removing generic methodological and academic descriptors, shifting the representation from surface-level variation toward the field’s substantive conceptual core. The network appears dense, although this likely reflects shared citation practices rather than conceptual consensus. Despite spanning performance auditing, CSR, and ESG assurance, the literature converges around a shared core of audit, assurance, firms, reporting quality, and governance. Cluster differences are matters of emphasis rather than isolation: performance audit research foregrounds public-sector accountability, while sustainability studies prioritize organizational transparency and stakeholder expectations. Their dense interconnection indicates that NFIA research is structured by common institutional logics rather than fragmented silos.

While these bibliometric results map conceptual proximity and thematic concentration, they remain relational. To move beyond descriptive mapping toward analytical depth, the next stage adopts the “accounting complex” framework (Miller & Power, 2013) as a sensitizing device. This framework guides the inductive, full-text coding necessary to examine how NFIA research substantively constructs auditability, legitimacy, and professional roles. This narrative synthesis shifts focus from surface-level regularities to the empirical problematics and practices that animate the literature.

## Analysis and Thematic Synthesis

*Analytical framework and thematic development*

The analytical core of this review is grounded in the "accounting complex" (Miller & Power, 2013). This framework conceptualizes auditing as an intervention linking calculation, governance, and expertise, making it uniquely suited to interrogating the bibliometric connections between NFIA and its adjacent domains. Mobilizing this framework as a sensitizing device allows the review to move beyond surface-level proximity to examine the concrete mechanisms through which NFIA operates in practice.

Viewed through this lens, the keyword network (Figure 4) aligns with the four interrelated roles of the accounting complex:

- Subjectivizing (Red Cluster): Centres on professional identity, trust, and socialization, emphasizing the construction of auditor expertise and credibility.
- Territorializing (Green/Yellow Cluster): Focused on supreme audit institutions, government, and jurisdiction, reflecting how auditing delineates governable spaces.
- Mediating (Blue Cluster): Organises around sustainability, stakeholders, and evidence, highlighting assurance as a boundary mechanism translating heterogeneous concerns into credible forms.
- Adjudicating (Purple/Orange Clusters): Associated with risk, financial distress,

and investors, concerning the evaluation of performance and consequences.

These dimensions are not discrete categories but patterns of emphasis; their dense interconnection indicates that NFIA research routinely mobilizes multiple dimensions simultaneously.

This structure was developed through an abductive process. Following bibliometric mapping, inductive full-text coding captured empirical problematics, which were then interpreted through Miller and Power's (2013) vocabulary. This iterative movement revealed four dominant thematic constellations. While each theme resonates with specific dimensions of the accounting complex, they represent empirically grounded problem spaces where territorializing, mediating, adjudicating, and subjectivizing processes are intertwined. This approach ensures analytical rigor while preserving the complexity of the NFIA literature.

| VOSviewer colour cluster | Representative keywords | Accounting complex (Miller & Power, 2013) | Key theme in this review | Rationale for the linkage |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Red** | *profession; auditor; accountant; trust; logic; meaning; socialisation; client; user* | Subjectivising | Inter-professional Dynamics and the Sociology of the Profession | • Cluster centres on actors and identity terms (*auditor, profession*).<br>• Dense ties to legitimacy-signalling concepts (*trust, meaning, logic*).<br>• This vocabulary foregrounds how NFIA constitutes credible professional subjects and inter-professional boundaries. |
| **Green**<br>**Yellow** | *supreme audit institution; government; accountability; implementation; jurisdiction; court; parliament; local government* | Territorialising | NFIA as a Socially Constructed and Institutional Practice | • Cluster anchors on institutional sites and objects of audit (*SAI, government*).<br>• Keywords imply boundary-setting and systematisation (*jurisdiction, implementation, accountability*).<br>• This points to the construction of auditable domains and governable spaces. |
| **Blue** | *sustainability; corporate social responsibility; stakeholder; engagement; evidence; service; perception; demand* | Mediating | The Broader Political and Managerial Utility of NFIA | • Cluster centres on assurance as an interface (*service, engagement*).<br>• Strong links to disclosure domains and audiences (*CSR, sustainability, stakeholder*).<br>• Keywords imply translation of diverse information into credible forms (*evidence, quality*). |
| **Purple**<br>**Orange** | *firm; risk; competition; financial distress likelihood; investor; decision; information asymmetry; cost; intention; ESG* | Adjudicating | Determinants and Consequences of NFIA | • Cluster vocabulary is evaluative and outcome-oriented (*risk, distress, investor, information asymmetry*).<br>• It tracks determinants (why assurance is adopted) and consequences (market/behavioural effects).<br>• This mirrors adjudicating: evaluating success/failure and attributing performance effects. |

**Table 5. Mapping VOSviewer keyword clusters to the accounting complex and empirically derived themes**

*Source: Author's analysis, informed by Miller and Power (2013)*

Following the stabilization of the four overarching themes, iterative full-text reading of all 124 studies captured research motivations, theoretical engagements, and empirical findings. This deductive–inductive procedure identified thirteen granular sub-themes representing recurring empirical problematics within the thematic domains. These sub-themes reflect how NFIA research examines professional dynamics, institutional construction, and governance utility at a higher resolution. The following section moves from classification to narrative synthesis, analysing how these themes and sub-themes are substantively developed and theoretically mobilized within the NFIA literature.

*Meta-synthesis of empirical NFIA research themes*

| Temporal Evolution of NFIA Research Themes | 1995–1999 | 2000-2004 | 2005-2009 | 2010-2014 | 2015-2019 | 2020-2025 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Inter-professional Dynamics and the Sociology of the Profession** | | | | | | |
| Jurisdictional Competition | | 2 | 1 | 1 | 2 | 2 |
| Professional Identity | 1 | | 1 | 2 | 2 | 4 |
| Team Dynamics | | | | | 2 | |
| **NFIA as a Socially Constructed and Institutional Practice** | | | | | | |
| Legitimacy Work | 1 | | | | 2 | 5 |
| Ritual and Symbolism | 1 | 2 | | 1 | 3 | |
| The "Black Box" of Practice | | 3 | 3 | 4 | 7 | 3 |
| **The Broader Political and Managerial Utility of NFIA** | | | | | | |
| Democratic Accountability | | | | 1 | 1 | 2 |
| Internal Utility | | 1 | | 1 | 5 | |
| Political Utility | | | 1 | | 2 | 3 |
| **Determinants and Consequences of NFIA** | | | | | | |
| Assurance & Greenwashing | | | 1 | | 2 | 5 |
| Capital Market Consequences | | | | | 3 | 7 |
| Governance Drivers | 1 | 1 | 1 | 1 | 9 | 9 |
| Auditor/Investor/Consumer Behaviour | 1 | 1 | | 1 | 3 | 6 |
| **Total for the period** | 5 | 10 | 8 | 12 | 43 | 46 |

| Thematic Distribution by NFIA Subject Domain | CSR/ESG/Sustainability | Performance Audit | Carbon (GHG) | Other |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Inter-professional Dynamics and the Sociology of the Profession** | | | | |
| Jurisdictional Competition | 5 | 1 | 1 | 1 |
| Professional Identity | 5 | 3 | | 2 |
| Team Dynamics | | | 2 | |
| **NFIA as a Socially Constructed and Institutional Practice** | | | | |
| Legitimacy Work | 4 | 4 | | |
| Ritual and Symbolism | 5 | 2 | | |
| The "Black Box" of Practice | 9 | 11 | | |
| **The Broader Political and Managerial Utility of NFIA** | | | | |
| Democratic Accountability | | 4 | | |
| Internal Utility | 1 | 6 | | |
| Political Utility | 2 | 4 | | |
| **Determinants and Consequences of NFIA** | | | | |
| Assurance & Greenwashing | 7 | | 1 | |
| Capital Market Consequences | 10 | | | |
| Governance Drivers | 19 | | 3 | |
| Auditor/Investor/Consumer Behaviour | 9 | 1 | 1 | 1 |
| **Total for the period** | 76 | 36 | 8 | 4 |

| Thematic Concentration across Journal Outlets | FA&M | AAAJ | JBE | IJA | AJPT | MAJ | MAR | AOS | CPA | BAR | Other |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Inter-professional Dynamics and the Sociology of the Profession** | | | | | | | | | | | |
| Jurisdictional Competition | 1 | 2 | | 1 | | 1 | | | | 1 | 2 |
| Professional Identity | 1 | 2 | 1 | 2 | 1 | 1 | | | | | 2 |
| Team Dynamics | | | | | 1 | | | | | | 1 |
| **NFIA as a Socially Constructed and Institutional Practice** | | | | | | | | | | | |
| Legitimacy Work | 3 | 2 | 1 | | | | | | | | 2 |
| Ritual and Symbolism | 1 | | 1 | | | 2 | | | | | 3 |
| The "Black Box" of Practice | 4 | 4 | 2 | | | | | 2 | 4 | | 4 |
| **The Broader Political and Managerial Utility of NFIA** | | | | | | | | | | | |
| Democratic Accountability | 3 | | | | | | | | 1 | | |
| Internal Utility | 1 | | | 2 | | 2 | | | | | 2 |
| Political Utility | 2 | | | 1 | | 1 | | | | | 2 |
| **Determinants and Consequences of NFIA** | | | | | | | | | | | |
| Assurance & Greenwashing | | | 1 | | 1 | | 1 | | | 1 | 4 |
| Capital Market Consequences | | 1 | | 3 | 1 | | 1 | | | 1 | 3 |
| Governance Drivers | | 1 | 4 | | 3 | 2 | 3 | 1 | | 2 | 6 |
| Auditor/Investor/Consumer Behaviour | | 1 | 2 | 2 | 2 | | 1 | 2 | | | 2 |
| **Total for the period** | 16 | 13 | 12 | 11 | 9 | 9 | 6 | 5 | 5 | 5 | 33 |

| Methodological Preferences by Research Theme | Quantitative Methods | | | Qualitative Methods | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Archival / statistical analysis | Experimental / quasi-experimental | Survey | Case study | Discourse / content analysis | Document / textual analysis | Interview study | Participant observation |
| **Inter-professional Dynamics and the Sociology of the Profession** | | | | | | | | |
| Jurisdictional Competition | 1 | | 2 | 1 | 1 | | 3 | |
| Professional Identity | 1 | 1 | 3 | 1 | | 1 | 2 | 1 |
| Team Dynamics | | 1 | 1 | | | | | |
| **NFIA as a Socially Constructed and Institutional Practice** | | | | | | | | |
| Legitimacy Work | 2 | | | 3 | 1 | 1 | 1 | |
| Ritual and Symbolism | | | 1 | 1 | 1 | 1 | 3 | |
| The "Black Box" of Practice | | | | 9 | 1 | 2 | 8 | |
| **The Broader Political and Managerial Utility of NFIA** | | | | | | | | |
| Democratic Accountability | | | | 2 | | 2 | | |
| Internal Utility | 1 | | 4 | | 1 | | 1 | |
| Political Utility | 3 | | | 2 | | 1 | | |
| **Determinants and Consequences of NFIA** | | | | | | | | |
| Assurance & Greenwashing | 5 | | | 1 | 1 | 1 | | |
| Capital Market Consequences | 10 | | | | | | | |
| Governance Drivers | 16 | | 4 | | | 2 | | |
| Auditor/Investor/Consumer Behaviour | | 10 | 1 | | | | 1 | |
| **Total for the period** | 39 | 12 | 16 | 20 | 6 | 11 | 19 | 1 |

**Table 6. A multi-dimensional meta-synthesis of empirical NFIA research themes**

*Source: Author's analysis*

Rather than mapping alone, the synthesis highlights what the field consistently examines—and what it tends to leave untouched, showing how the structure of NFIA research determines what can be governed. The field configuration reveals a pronounced orientation toward market-facing outcomes; NFIA is rendered legible primarily through economic consequences, while internal audit mechanics remain obscured (Fuhrmann, Ott, Looks and Guenther, 2017; Chi, Cheng and Wang, 2020; Carey, Khan, Mihret and Muttakin, 2021). As NFIA research shifted from public-sector accountability to market-oriented governance, methodological inquiry converged around quantitative analyses of determinants and consequences. This empirical infrastructure privileges outcomes that are standardized and comparable across jurisdictions (Clarkson, Li, Richardson and Tsang, 2019; Sánchez-Sancho, Martínez-Ferrero and Perote-Peña, 2025). Consequently, assurance is examined more through its effects on pricing and risk than through the situated interactions constituting audit practice (Perego & Kolk, 2012; Owen, Swift, Humphrey and Bowerman, 2000).

The methodological cleavage in the literature illustrates this dynamic. Archival approaches frame assurance as an adjudicating device valued for signalling and risk mitigation (Liao, Teng and Zhang, 2018; Chi *et al.*, 2020). While investors occasionally peer into the "black box" by differentiating based on scope (Fuhrmann *et al.*, 2017; Sánchez-Sancho *et al.*, 2025), reputational heuristics and provider identity frequently substitute for engagement with actual assurance processes (Clarkson *et al.*, 2019; Oware & Appiah, 2022).

Qualitative research offers a counterpoint, foregrounding negotiated materiality, "dry runs," and the co-construction of auditability (O'Dwyer, 2011; Channuntapipat *et al.*, 2019). These studies prove that outcomes are shaped by professional judgment rather than mechanical standards. However, their relative isolation suggests a structural asymmetry: core audit practices resist reduction into variables because their authority relies on tacit expertise and discretion (Canning, O'Dwyer and Georgakopoulos, 2019; Farooq & de Villiers, 2019).

Meaningful absences also exist. The lack of quantitative research in performance audit reflects state-based accountability regimes, where audit operates via parliamentary reporting and politically cautious disclosure rather than market adjudication (Guthrie & Parker, 1999; Parker *et al.*, 2019). That said, the carbon (GHG) domain foregrounds team dynamics, signalling the normalization of multidisciplinary expertise (Green *et al.*, 2017; Ekasingh, Simnett and Green, 2019). Here, the auditor is a coordinating actor within hybrid calculative arrangements (Kim, Green and Johnstone, 2016).

The concentration of market studies in CSR/ESG research points to a broader financialisation of non-financial assurance. Post-2015 growth represents a consolidation around legitimacy and market relevance rather than balanced diversification. While this stabilizes assurance as an institutional credibility mechanism, it leaves the "organizational intervention" aspect under-theorized. Internal utility functions—such as "suggestion effects" and process improvement (Xing *et al.*, 2025; Hummel *et al.*, 2019)—remain fragmented. This leaves unresolved tensions between assurance as a credibility

tool and as a catalyst for substantive change, particularly given the prevalence of limited assurance and reliance on internal data (Bepari & Mollik, 2016; Gu *et al*., 2023).

*From Heatmap Constraints to Sub-theme Deepening*

The preceding meta-synthesis utilized a dominant-theme classification to preserve interpretability. However, this methodological constraint does not reflect the substantive reality of NFIA research, which routinely spans professional identity, jurisdictional work, and audit practice. Consequently, the aggregate heatmaps capture field-level orientations while necessitating a more fine-grained interrogation at the sub-theme level. By reopening the analytical space, we examine how inter-professional dynamics operate across the literature. This aligns with Miller and Power's (2013) view of auditing as a set of practices that shape subjectivities and modes of participation in governance. While our abductive coding precludes a direct mapping onto the "subjectivizing" function, focusing on what is foregrounded provides a productive lens for identifying both theoretical alignment and the field's original contributions to governance theory.

*Inter-professional Dynamics and the Sociology of the Profession*

The jurisdictional competition literature positions sustainability assurance as an arena of professional struggle in which accounting firms and specialist providers contest authority over methods, standards, and evaluative criteria (Channuntapipat *et al*., 2019; Boiral *et al*., 2019). In mature markets such as Australia, Italy, and South Africa, this struggle has increasingly stabilised in favour of large accounting firms, reflecting the extension of financial audit logics into non-financial domains through reputational branding, regulatory alignment, and the institutionalisation of procedural assurance frameworks ((Larrinaga, Rossi, Luque-Vílchez and Núñez-Solidoro, 2018; Ackers, 2009;

Bradbury, Jia and Li, 2022). By contrast, more fragmented markets such as the United States and New Zealand continue to accommodate engineering-led and boutique providers, indicating that jurisdictional settlement remains historically contingent and shaped by national regulatory trajectories rather than technical competence alone (Casey & Grenier, 2015; Bentley-Goode, Simnett, Thompson and Trotman, 2024).

Although this literature appears, on its surface, to operate at a field level, its dynamics can be reinterpreted through the lens of the accounting complex. In Miller and Power (2013)'s terms, subjectivization refers to the production of actors who come to understand responsibility, choice, and accountability through calculative norms. From this perspective, jurisdictional conflict is not external to subjectivization but constitutes one of its mechanisms. Competing assurance frameworks and professional logics reshape what it means to be an assurer. Accounting firms promote subject positions centred on procedural rigour, risk management, and auditability through the privileging of ISAE 3000, while specialist providers advance alternative subjectivities grounded in contextual expertise, stakeholder engagement, and narrative justification, often articulated through AA1000 (Bepari & Mollik, 2016; Perego & Kolk, 2012; Hummel *et al.*, 2019).

These dynamics are reinforced through responsibilisation. Miller and Power (2013) emphasise that accounting renders individuals responsible by tying them to specific calculative regimes. In sustainability assurance, the selection and enforcement of assurance standards exact responsibility from practitioners by enrolling them into distinct evaluative frameworks, each with different expectations regarding evidence, judgement, and accountability (Farooq & de Villiers, 2019; Boiral *et al.*, 2019).

Jurisdictional competition thus functions as a struggle over which calculative subjectivities become dominant and which responsibilities are rendered legitimate.

Accounting firms' relative success in this struggle reflects their capacity to institutionalise their metrics as authoritative tools of adjudication. Miller and Power (2013) argue that accounting's power lies in its ability to define what constitutes success and failure. By embedding audit-derived measures and assurance language within regulatory and market infrastructures, accounting firms position procedural verification as the legitimate basis for adjudicating sustainability performance, marginalising alternative evaluative logics as insufficiently objective or rigorous (Ackers, 2009; Clarkson *et al*., 2019).

Yet this stabilisation remains partial and unstable. The procedural, and often anti-managerial, logic of ISAE-based assurance can clash with the narrative, strategic, and forward-looking objectives of sustainability managers, reproducing tensions between auditability and organisational storytelling (Maltby, 1995; Channuntapipat *et al*., 2019). Moreover, the persistence of fragmented markets and hybrid arrangements—particularly in GHG assurance, where cooperative and multidisciplinary models are observed—reflects what Miller and Power (2013) describe as the accounting complex's condition of constant reform and endemic failure to stabilise a single, global logic. Rather than anomalies, these fragmentations signal the fluidity and historical contingency of subjectivization processes within non-financial assurance (Canning *et al*., 2019; Martínez-Ferrero, Sánchez-Sancho and García-Meca, 2025; Mnif & Kchaou, 2025).

*NFIA as a Socially Constructed and Institutional Practice*

In Miller and Power (2013)'s framework, territorialising refers to the recursive construction of calculable spaces—both physical and abstract—within which organisational conduct can be rendered visible, comparable, and governable. Accounting does not merely measure activities that already exist; it draws an "envelope" around selected objects, actors, and processes, thereby defining what lies inside the domain of accountability and what is positioned outside its scope (Miller and Power, 2013). Read through this lens, the NFIA literature reveals assurance as a key mechanism through which sustainability and public accountability are spatially organised and made administrable.

A primary means of territorialising in NFIA is the mimicry of financial audit. By importing mediating instruments such as materiality thresholds, risk assessments, and structured assurance methodologies, practitioners translate diffuse and contested sustainability concerns into bounded audit territories that resemble established financial reporting spaces (Canning *et al.*, 2019; Silvola and Vinnari, 2021; Farooq and de Villiers, 2019). In Miller and Power (2013)'s terms, these mediating instruments link macro-level demands for transparency and control with micro-level audit routines, making sustainability "thinkable and actionable" in calculative form. Assurance thus does not simply evaluate performance; it actively constructs the space within which performance can be judged.

Territorialisation is closely tied to the production of facticity and objectivity. Miller and Power (2013) emphasise that accounting technologies generate authoritative inscriptions that acquire the status of facts, appearing objective and beyond the reach of politics. In NFIA, assurance statements and audit reports stabilise contested social and

environmental issues by transforming them into technical outcomes, effectively "cooling" controversy through calculation (Skærbæk, 2009; Skærbæk and Christensen, 2015). This process underpins forms of managerialisation in which political or ethical concerns are reframed as technical management problems solvable through appropriate assurance techniques (Radcliffe, 2008; Islam, Deegan and Gray, 2018; Rohani, Jabbour and Aliyu, 2023).

The literature exposes the loose coupling between these calculative envelopes (Miller and Power, 2013) and underlying practices. Backstage negotiations, pre-assurance reviews, and scope exclusions reveal how assurance territories are continuously adjusted to ensure manageability and avoid disruptive findings (O'Dwyer *et al.*, 2011; Channuntapipat *et al.*, 2019; Farooq and de Villiers, 2019). Consistent with Miller and Power (2013)'s argument that accounting elaboration often proceeds regardless of functional effectiveness, these practices help explain why NFIA can sustain legitimacy and order even when substantive change is limited (Morin, 2016; Boiral *et al.*, 2019).

Finally, digital infrastructures further entrench territorial boundaries. Data architectures, algorithms, and reporting platforms operate as non-human elements of the accounting complex, embedding calculative choices into organisational environments and constraining what auditors can observe and contest (Aquino *et al.*, 2022). As Miller and Power (2013) argue, such artefacts are not neutral tools but integral technologies through which programmes of accountability are realised and stabilised.

*The Broader Political and Managerial Utility of NFIA*

In the framework developed by Miller and Power (2013), mediating refers to accounting's capacity to link otherwise distinct actors, aspirations, and arenas through shared narratives and calculative practices. Accounting does not merely record or verify; it operationalises abstract political and managerial ideals—such as efficiency, accountability, or public value—by embedding them within concrete routines, reports, and evaluative devices. Read through this lens, the NFIA literature reveals a marked asymmetry in how mediating functions are examined across assurance domains.

This mediating role is most explicitly theorised and empirically documented in performance audit, where assurance practices are shown to connect macro-level political ambitions with micro-level administrative action. Performance audits routinely mediate between Parliament, executives, auditors, media, and citizens by translating broad democratic aspirations—scrutiny of power, value for money, responsible stewardship—into technical audit findings that can travel across institutional arenas (Guthrie and Parker, 1999; Morin, 2011; Parker *et al.*, 2019). Audit reports function as boundary objects that simultaneously support legislative oversight, managerial reform, and political contestation, even when these objectives sit in tension with one another (Funnell, Wade and Jupe, 2016; Lapsley and Vakkuri, 2002). In Miller and Power (2013)'s terms, performance audit operates as a mediating dispositif precisely because its inscriptions are sufficiently stable to circulate, yet sufficiently ambiguous to align diverse interests.

The same literature also demonstrates that mediation often thrives on ambiguity rather than precision. Performance audit findings are frequently mobilised as political

ammunition, managerial guidance, and symbolic reassurance at once, allowing different actors to appropriate the same calculative artefact for divergent ends (Rika and Jacobs, 2019; Hazgui, Triantafillou and Elmer Christensen, 2022). This loose coupling between political ideals and organisational outcomes reflects Miller and Power (2013)'s observation that accounting reforms proliferate even where functional impacts are uncertain, sustaining legitimacy through symbolic alignment rather than substantive resolution (Morin, 2016; Cordery, Arora and Manochin, 2023).

By contrast, CSR/ESG assurance research has tended to foreground market-facing governance questions—such as credibility, signalling, and information risk—more than the broader political and managerial mediations emphasised in performance-audit research (Casey & Grenier, 2015; Clarkson *et al*., 2019; Fuhrmann *et al*., 2017). Review-based syntheses similarly organise CSR/ESG assurance primarily around domain-specific assurance elements and greenwashing/credibility concerns, leaving the mediating role of assurance comparatively under-theorised (Farooq *et al*., 2023; Free, Jones & Tremblay, 2024). This absence is analytically significant. From a mediating perspective, CSR/ESG assurance must also connect corporate practices to regulatory expectations, investor narratives, societal values, and, increasingly, public policy goals. The concentration of mediating analyses in performance audit therefore signals not a domain-specific property, but a research gap: the political and managerial utility of CSR/ESG assurance remains under-theorised, despite its growing role in shaping how sustainability is governed, contested, and legitimated across organisational and political arenas (Miller and Power, 2013).

*Determinants and Consequences of NFIA*

The Determinants and Consequences stream is analytically distinctive within the NFIA literature because it is overwhelmingly dominated by quantitative archival and experimental designs. These studies typically proceed from a positivist assumption that assurance quality and effects are objectively observable—manifesting, for example, in reduced bid–ask spreads, lower costs of equity and debt, diminished stock crash risk, fewer restatements, or improved disclosure credibility (Ballou, Chen, Grenier and Heitger, 2015; Casey and Grenier, 2015; Chi *et al.*, 2020; Pinnuck, Simnett, Soderstrom and Zhou, 2021; Sánchez-Sancho *et al.*, 2025; Yang and Maresova, 2025). Read through the framework developed by Miller and Power (2013), however, these empirical regularities can be reinterpreted not as neutral measurements of "better" assurance, but as evidence of accounting's adjudicating capacity—its ability to define success and failure, allocate responsibility, and stabilise norms of appropriate organisational conduct.

Miller and Power (2013) emphasise that adjudication is not simply a technical outcome of calculation, but a socially legitimated practice imbued with latent normativity. Accounting acquires authority precisely because it renders organisations into "entities of a certain kind" that can be evaluated, compared, and judged (Miller and Power, 2013). The capital-market literature on sustainability assurance exemplifies this process. Findings that assurance reduces information asymmetry and risk (Fuhrmann *et al.*, 2017; Chi *et al.*, 2020; Sánchez-Sancho *et al.*, 2025) document how adjudicatory inscriptions—assurance opinions, provider identities, assurance levels—circulate as abbreviated verdicts of organisational virtue. Importantly, adjudication does not operate solely through technical detail. While some evidence shows that investors differentiate based

on scope and level of assurance (Fuhrmann *et al*., 2017; Sánchez-Sancho *et al*., 2025), other studies demonstrate reliance on reputational heuristics, particularly the symbolic authority of Big 4 providers (Clarkson *et al*., 2019; Oware and Appiah, 2022). This tension illustrates Miller and Power (2013)'s claim that adjudication functions as a widely diffused "style of thought," rather than a purely rational calculus.

The Assurance and Greenwashing sub-stream further exposes adjudication's ambivalence. Assurance is shown to deter symbolic disclosure and detect errors (Ballou *et al*., 2015; Pinnuck *et al*., 2021; Bentley *et al*., 2024), yet it can also be strategically constrained through limited scopes, provider shopping, and managerial capture, thereby sustaining a veneer of legitimacy without substantive change (Perego and Kolk, 2012; Casey and Grenier, 2015; Ackers, 2015). Paradoxical effects such as moral licensing—where ESG assurance facilitates more aggressive financial reporting—demonstrate how adjudicatory legitimacy may be transferred across domains once "good performance" is institutionally certified (Douthit, Kachelmeier and Van Landuyt, 2024), consistent with Miller and Power (2013)'s observation that adjudication expands readily to new objects of valuation.

A critical limitation of this stream lies in its empirical concentration. Adjudicatory effects are predominantly examined in CSR/ESG contexts where data infrastructures enable commensuration, while performance audit and emerging assurance domains remain largely absent due to their resistance to quantification. From a Miller and Power (2013) perspective, this signals a significant research opportunity. Adjudication is likely to be most formative at the inception of new assurance territories—such as carbon and climate assurance—before calculative infrastructures become blackboxed and their

normative assumptions taken for granted. The current literature therefore captures adjudication after it has stabilised, leaving under-explored the early moments when accounting actively makes up what counts as “good,” “bad,” or “credible” performance (Miller and Power, 2013).

## Discussion and Conclusion

*Revisiting the Audit Society through NFIA*

The empirical literature on NFIA has undergone a profound transformation over the past 35 years (Dalla Via & Perego, 2020; Funnell *et al*., 2016; Gipper *et al*., 2025; O'Dwyer, 2011). In the 1990s, the field was anchored in public-sector performance auditing and New Public Management (NPM) reforms, where state institutions sought to verify "value for money" (English, 2007; Funnell, 2015; Kastberg & Ek Österberg, 2017; Parker *et al*., 2019). During the 2000s, scholarly attention shifted towards corporate social responsibility (CSR) assurance as a voluntary mechanism for legitimacy repair following social and environmental controversies (Ackers & Eccles, 2015; Perego & Kolk, 2012; Simnett *et al*., 2009). In the current decade, the literature documents an unprecedented acceleration and diversification into ESG, carbon accounting, and digitally mediated assurance regimes (Aquino *et al*., 2022; Gipper *et al*., 2024; Gu *et al*., 2023). This trajectory indicates that NFIA has evolved from a peripheral governance device—often dismissed as symbolic (Boiral *et al*., 2019; Perego & Kolk, 2012; Power, 1997a)—into a core part of contemporary regulation (Gu *et al*., 2023; Rika & Jacobs, 2019).

This evolution signals a qualitative shift from audit as an episodic practice to audit as a pervasive infrastructure. Mobilising Power's (2003b) refinement of the audit explosion, the review shows that NFIA is no longer discretionary or marginal. Instead, it increasingly operates as a form of "control of control", embedded within internal data architectures, governance routines, and automated reporting systems (Ackers, 2009; Aquino *et al*., 2022; Gu *et al*., 2023). In this sense, the audit society has matured into what can be

described as an audit planet, where verification is not merely reactive but constitutive of how organisational and regulatory spaces are rendered governable.

NFIA provides a privileged empirical site for evaluating these developments because, unlike financial auditing, it remains visibly "in the making". Financial audit has been largely stabilised and blackboxed through long-standing professional settlement. By contrast, NFIA is characterised by experimentation, contestation, and failure, as illustrated by the rise and decline of initiatives such as WebTrust (Barrett & Gendron, 2006; Gendron, Cooper and Townley, 2007) and the ongoing difficulties surrounding greenhouse gas (GHG) assurance (Green & Li, 2011). The emergence of hybrid teams, negotiated auditability, and unstable standards renders the backstage mechanics of verification unusually visible, making NFIA fertile ground for empirically examining Power's later refinements of the audit society.

*Legitimacy without Observation*

A dominant pattern identified across the review is the production of procedural legitimacy, lending strong empirical support to Power's (2003a) argument that audit quality is defined internally within the profession rather than through direct observation. NFIA legitimacy is repeatedly shown to be constructed through standardised templates, ISAE 3000 work programmes, and the formalisation of working papers (Boiral *et al.*, 2019; Bepari & Mollik, 2016; Larrinaga *et al.*, 2018). These artefacts stabilise uncertainty inherent in non-financial data, translating heterogeneous social and environmental claims into defensible and auditable representations.

This procedural legitimacy is reinforced through pre-assurance “dry runs” and backstage negotiations between assurors and auditees. Such practices operate as purification mechanisms (Power, 2003a), identifying and neutralising potential audit failures prior to the issuance of the assurance statement (Farooq & de Villiers, 2019; Channuntapipat *et al*., 2019; O’Dwyer *et al*., 2011). By the time NFIA outputs reach external audiences, the contingent and negotiated nature of underlying performance has been largely erased, replaced by a rationalised narrative of compliance and rigour.

Importantly, the review suggests that NFIA radicalises procedural legitimacy beyond the conditions originally analysed by Power. In domains such as carbon sequestration, climate modelling, or forward-looking transition risk, physical observation is often structurally impossible. In these settings, assurance becomes largely self-referential: legitimacy is derived almost exclusively from adherence to calculative protocols rather than correspondence with an observable reality (Boiral *et al*., 2019; Taylor *et al*., 2001). Despite this, much of the empirical literature remains weakly reflexive, continuing to treat assurance as a proxy for objective performance rather than interrogating the procedural rituals through which such objectivity is produced (O’Dwyer *et al*., 2011; Boiral *et al*., 2019).

*Symbolic Verification and the Comfort Function*

Whereas procedural legitimacy concerns how assurance stabilises itself internally as a credible practice, the comfort function captures how that credibility is mobilised externally to reassure markets and stakeholders.

The CSR and ESG assurance literature strongly corroborates the "comfort function" identified in the audit society thesis (Power, 1997a). Rather than driving substantive organisational transformation, NFIA frequently operates as a ritual of verification that produces reassurance for investors and regulators (Fuhrmann *et al.*, 2017; Clarkson *et al.*, 2019). Clear displacement effects are evident, whereby documentation and symbolic disclosure become ends in themselves, increasingly decoupled from underlying social or environmental outcomes (Perego & Kolk, 2012; Bepari & Mollik, 2016).

This symbolic verification is mediated through reputational heuristics and moral licensing. The presence of a Big 4 assurance provider frequently substitutes for scrutiny of assurance scope or depth (Clarkson *et al.*, 2019; Casey & Grenier, 2015; Yang & Maresova, 2025). While provider identity underwrites investment decisions and risk assessments, moral licensing effects suggest that ESG assurance may also legitimise aggressive financial reporting or continued environmental externalisation (Douthit *et al.*, 2024).

A key contribution of the NFIA literature is showing that comfort production has migrated from public-sector governance into financialised markets. Whereas Power (1997a) framed audit as governing at a distance within the state, NFIA now operates as a market-facing infrastructure supplying the institutional comfort required for the circulation of capital under uncertainty.

*Control of Control in Non-Financial Domains*

Consistent with Power's (2003b) analysis, NFIA research confirms a marked shift away from first-order operational scrutiny towards the "control of control". Assurors rarely verify actual environmental or social impacts, focusing instead on the management systems and internal controls through which organisations claim to measure those impacts (Owen *et al.*, 2000; Bepari & Mollik, 2016; Hummel *et al.*, 2019). This systems-oriented focus privileges procedural integrity over substantive outcomes.

The implications for accountability are significant. Environmental and social problems are reframed as technical matters of risk management and compliance, facilitating blame avoidance and liability management (Skærbæk & Christensen, 2015; Radcliffe, 2008; Cordery & Hay, 2019). In this process, political and ethical dimensions are cooled and transformed into governable calculative territories.

In domains such as climate change and ESG, this control-of-control logic is not merely strategic but often unavoidable. Where phenomena are diffuse, uncertain, or future-oriented, auditing management systems becomes the primary means of enacting accountability. NFIA thus intensifies the dynamics identified by Power (2003b), rendering system-level control the dominant object of governance.

*Professional Identities in an Audit Planet*

NFIA constitutes a critical site for the production of new calculative subjectivities. The literature documents hybrid professional identities, including sustainability auditors navigating tensions between accounting logic and scientific expertise, and

professionalised auditees adept at managing inspection regimes (Maltby, 1995; O'Dwyer, 2011; Gillet-Monjarret, 2022).

Jurisdictional competition between accounting firms and specialist providers reflects competing constructions of professional selfhood. Standards such as ISAE 3000 and AA1000 embed distinct logics of responsibility, privileging procedural rigour or stakeholder engagement respectively (Boiral *et al.*, 2019; Bepari & Mollik, 2016; Farooq & de Villiers, 2019). The growing dominance of accounting firms signals a subjectivisation of the assuror as a risk-oriented procedural actor.

Conversely, professional identities remain unstable. As NFIA increasingly relies on multidisciplinary, team-based models—particularly in carbon assurance—the auditor is no longer a singular professional subject. Instead, assurance is assembled through distributed expertise and layered review hierarchies (Canning *et al.*, 2019; Green *et al.*, 2017; Ekasingh *et al.*, 2019). In the audit planet, professional identity becomes situational and continuously reconfigured.

*From Audit Society to Audit Planet*

Taken together, the findings indicate that NFIA represents a qualitative evolution of the audit society diagnosed by Power. While the audit explosion was initially framed as the diffusion of verification practices into new domains, contemporary NFIA reveals a further transformation: audit has become infrastructural, generative, and constitutive of the objects it governs. NFIA does not merely extend audit techniques into sustainability

and climate reporting; it participates in constructing the conditions under which these domains become auditable (Power, 1996; Aquino *et al*., 2022; Gu *et al*., 2023).

Across the literature, assurance no longer appears as an episodic intervention but as an organising logic embedded within data infrastructures, management systems, and governance routines. Carbon emissions, social impacts, and sustainability risks are rendered auditable not because they are inherently measurable, but because calculative envelopes are drawn around them, stabilising uncertainty through procedural legitimacy, symbolic verification, and system-level control (Power, 1996; Power, 2003b).

The concept of an audit planet is advanced here as an analytical extension rather than a rejection of the audit society thesis. In this configuration, audit becomes a background condition of governance itself, shaping problem framing, responsibility allocation, expertise formation, and legitimacy performance across organisational and political arenas. This shift is not confined to advanced economies: NFIA is expanding rapidly across developed and developing contexts, governing increasingly atmospheric and future-oriented phenomena (Carey, Khan, Mihret and Muttakin, 2021; Oware & Appiah, 2022; Tetteh, Agyenim-Boateng and Simpson, 2023).

Meanwhile, the audit planet remains fragmented and unstable. Persistent tensions between procedural legitimacy and substantive accountability, symbolic comfort and behavioural change, and professional jurisdictions and hybrid expertise are not anomalies but constitutive features. Consistent with Power's emphasis on endemic failure and continual reform, NFIA emerges as a site in which auditability is continuously negotiated rather than progressively perfected.

*Conclusion*

This review examined how the empirical literature on non-financial information assurance has developed over the past 35 years and assessed the extent to which it engages—explicitly or implicitly—with Power's later refinements of the audit society. The analysis shows a shift from early public-sector accountability concerns (Cordery & Hay, 2022; English, 2003; Nath, Othman and Laswad, 2019) towards market-facing governance (Moroney *et al*., 2012; Taylor *et al*., 2001), system-based control (English, 2007; Kastberg & Ek Österberg, 2017), and capital-market consequences (Baier, Göttsche, Hellmann and Schiemann, 2022; Caglio, Melloni and Perego, 2020), reflecting the deep entrenchment of audit logics within sustainability, ESG, and climate governance (Bouten & Hoozée, 2025; Parker *et al*., 2021; Silvola & Vinnari, 2021).

In addressing RQ2, the review demonstrates strong resonance between NFIA research and Power's later insights. Studies of pre-assurance practices, negotiated auditability, and working papers substantiate the claim that audit legitimacy is produced procedurally rather than observationally (Power, 2003a; Farooq & de Villiers, 2019; Channuntapipat *et al*., 2019). Research on symbolic verification, moral licensing, and reputational heuristics confirms the enduring comfort function of audit (Power, 1997a; Clarkson *et al*., 2019; Douthit *et al*., 2025). Analyses of system-focused assurance, risk management, and blame avoidance extend the control-of-control logic into non-financial domains characterised by uncertainty (Power, 2003b; Bepari & Mollik, 2016; Skærbæk & Christensen, 2015). Finally, work on professional identity and jurisdictional competition illustrates how audit subjectivities are actively constructed and destabilised within contemporary assurance practices (O'Dwyer, 2011; Boiral *et al*., 2019).

Despite this progress, empirical attention remains uneven. Adjudicatory effects are concentrated in CSR and ESG contexts where data infrastructures enable quantification, while performance audit and emerging domains—most notably carbon and climate assurance—remain under-explored (Datt, Luo, Tang and Mallik, 2018; Green & Taylor, 2013; Zhou, Simnett and Green, 2016). Consequently, much of the literature captures audit after its calculative assumptions have stabilised (Power, 1996), leaving formative moments of auditability construction insufficiently examined.

This review is subject to several limitations. First, it focuses on empirical NFIA studies published in A and A* accounting and auditing journals, prioritising depth and theoretical coherence over breadth. As a result, relevant work in adjacent fields—such as science and technology studies, environmental governance, and legal scholarship—falls outside the scope of the analysis. Second, the review necessarily relies on published empirical accounts, which, by design, tend to examine assurance practices after calculative frameworks and standards have stabilised (Channuntapipat et al., 2019; Gendron & Barrett, 2004; Humphrey, 2008; O'Dwyer, 2011; Power, 1996). Consequently, early-stage struggles over auditability, as well as failed or abandoned initiatives, may be under-represented. Finally, while Power's (2003a, 2003b) later refinements provide a productive interpretive lens, they also shape what becomes visible in the synthesis; alternative theoretical framings may reveal different dynamics within the same corpus.

Future research should therefore focus on these early-stage dynamics, investigating how new assurance domains are assembled before becoming blackboxed (Humphrey, 2008; Power, 1996). Greater attention to hybrid assurance models, political and

managerial mediation, and lived audit subjectivities would deepen understanding of how the audit planet is being built and governed.

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